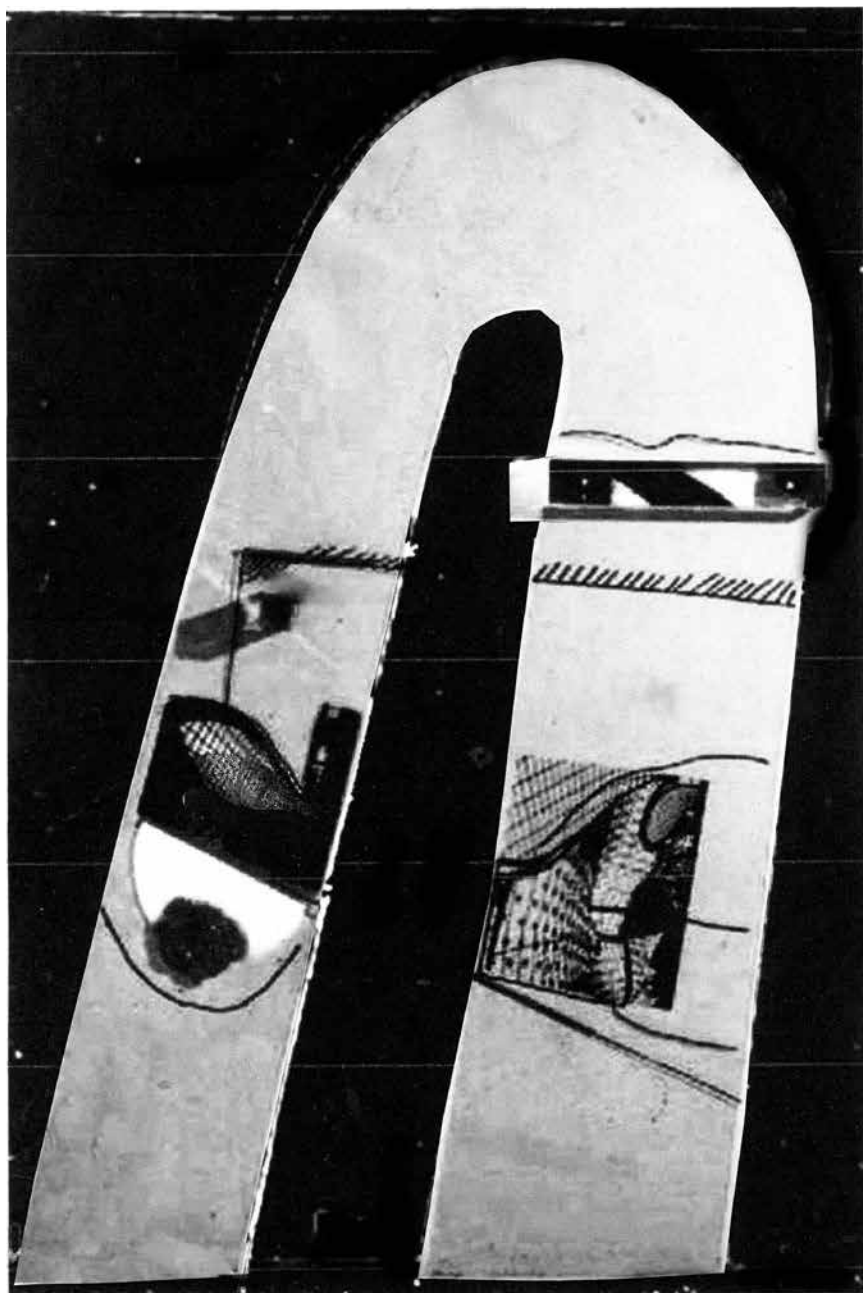




Agathe Sorel, *Welcome Arch*, sculpture with silkscreen, 1971

Chapter 5: Career 1967-1990

Atlantic City

I returned to the USA every year after completing my six months there, usually during the Easter break. These visits allowed me to meet many fascinating people. During one visit in the summer of 1967, Gabor and I took over a job from Sam Maitin, to be on the jury of the Atlantic City Sidewalk show, where artworks were shown along five kilometres of the beach. The prize money was very attractive, so a number of talented artists exhibited alongside rank amateurs. It was a fun day on the beach. Most of the jury travelled the length of the show on the boardwalk by jeep; my husband and I enjoyed the walk and talked to everyone. Names were difficult to remember in this multitude, so we took to describing the work in a tongue-in-cheek satirical manner. Unbelievably, whilst looking at our notes, all members of the jury, even the ones who drove by on the jeep, knew which artists we were talking about and the press recognized that we had done a thorough job and the choice of the winner was justified.

Sam Maitin also introduced us to a very wealthy couple, collectors of contemporary art, who owned a skyscraper at the edge of town. They occupied the penthouse apartment themselves, overlooking rolling parkland and the Potomac River. Their swimming pool on the 30th floor was constructed in such a way that the swimmers had the impression of floating over the landscape; the double doors of the roof terrace were left open for the occasion.

When the lavish dinner was over, we thanked our hosts for their hospitality and went to the lift. In our ignorance, we pressed the emergency button instead of the down button and immediately saw 5 or 6 police cars and an ambulance pulling up to the door on ground level. It was by then impossible to call them off.

Agathe Sorel, *Pool on the 30th Floor*, Line engraving, aquatint and surface printing from plastics and metal, 1966



Béla Kálmán

Whilst visiting the US, I renewed my acquaintance with Béla Kálmán, a nephew of my stepmother Lily. He took some good photos of me as a child. After being taken to a labour camp by the Nazis as a teenager he escaped by impersonating rubble-clearing engineers. Later he was apprenticed to a photographer who trained him. He then opened his own studio in Budapest.



Béla Kálmán

He fled as I did during the 1956 revolution and, sponsored by an aunt in Chicago, he moved there. He worked as a photographer for Life magazine before moving to New York. Later he moved to Boston in 1960, became an American citizen in 1962, and had his first exhibition there in 1964.

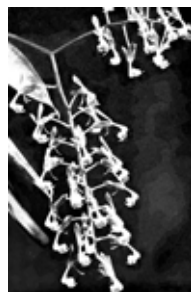
At about this time Edna Zimberg of Boston had purchased a photograph of flowers he has taken. They met and talked. Both divorced, they married in 1965. Edna was extremely wealthy and well-connected and owned a luxurious house in Boston and another one at Cape Cod. Her children were six and eight at the time, and Bela brought them up as if they were his own. The children even went on their honeymoon with them.

Theirs was a real love match, but a rather difficult one. Béla soon became the boss at the smart photo studio where they specialized in food photography. There he could experiment in his spare time to his heart's content but he had to make a profit. Edna was if anything, a realist. Béla came up with marvellous new techniques and ideas on level with the best fine artists and his work is in many museums.

Béla photographed Shiko Munakata in New York in the Chelsea Hotel where many artists lived and had their studios. Munakata lined all available surfaces with lining paper, then took a huge brush or broom and attacked these walls almost as if he was partaking in a martial art, achieving the most expressive spontaneous marks, without even making a sketch. He would then take the best of these calligraphic marks, arrange them in a composition and stick them down on planks of wood in the Japanese style to be cut with knives and gauges in an almost reproductive way. The wood thus carved was then dabbed or painted with ink to be hand printed on specially prepared paper. Béla gave us a signed print of this occasion as well as many other prints and books of his work.



Shiko Munakata
photographed by Béla
Kálmán, 1959



Béla Kálmán, *Flowers*,
From the book
Succulants published
in 2002

His book, *The Third Eye* contains a lot of photographs and experimental work, beautiful pictures of exotic flowers and sea creatures, landscape and portraits.

We visited Béla and Edna on many occasions in Boston and stayed with them at their lovely colonial home at Cape Cod of which we have memorable photographic records. Edna was severely diabetic, often passed into a coma and Béla saved her life many times. We got on very well and we joked that he was our best loved relative, when everyone else has died. In 2011, we were invited to Béla's goth birthday party, but were unable to go. We received a sad little note from Edna shortly afterwards saying "He left me". Sadly, he had passed away just a few weeks before his birthday and party.

György Kepes

I was greatly impressed and influenced by both his practical work and theoretical writings even before we met at one of Bela Kalman's parties at Cape Cod.



György Kepes

Béla was a great friend of György Kepes, the author of *The Language of Vision*, a famous photographer, film maker and educator committed to working with light, who created new perspectives through his experimental methods. They also had a house close by in Cape Cod.

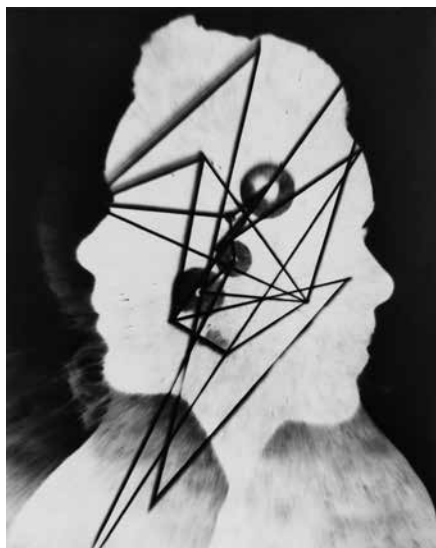
Although I only met György socially, I was greatly influenced by his work, when I started on my Space Engraving sculptures and related prints.

One of his descriptions, about the breakdown of fixed perspective certainly corresponded with my own experience.

György Képes was born in Hungary in 1906 and was trained at the Academy of Fine Arts by the Impressionist painter Istvan Csók. At the same time he was influenced by one of Hungary's most uncompromisingly modern poets and writers Lajos Kassák. He worked in Berlin at the Bauhaus with Laszlo Moholy-Nagy, an association he kept up all his life, following him to England and then to the USA. His work in film and his association with leading scientists and architects made him one of the most admired figures in the arts. He pioneered digital work and used sources not previously admitted as valid subject matters for the arts; such

Left: György Kepes,
Shadow Picture, 1938

Right: György Kepes,
Lily and Egg, 1939





Above: Gyorgy Kepes, *Bone Fragment, Stone Shadows*, 1939

Left: Gyorgy Kepes, *Woman in cube*, 1938

as X-ray, electro-microscope, infrared or deep sea and space exploration photos. His most important contribution may well lie in his photograms, where he placed both natural and scientific objects on light sensitive paper, without the use of a camera.

I found a similar method was most effective, when I used the photocopier to depict details of a 3D object like the veins of a dead cactus in my series and livre d'artiste *Catalana Blanca*.

<https://youtu.be/e66Z5WgDJW4> Moholy-Nagy photographic processes

https://youtu.be/ldvLkU_AqH8 John Halas in memory of Moholy-Nagy

Gyorgy Kepes Cameraless photography 1939

<https://youtu.be/BOErr8B4Hlw> exhibition at TATE Liverpool

According to Kepes, the language of vision is international and therefore does not need translation, but the education of vision is essential

The life work of Kepes has been recently re- evaluated in a large exhibition at Tate Liverpool and in the Victoria & Albert Museum in London. There is a special museum dedicated to his work in Eger, Hungary.



Gyorgy Kepes, *Face sculpture*, 1938

Space Engravings

My meeting with Charlie Kanev (see Chapter 4, page 103) and his gift to me of pieces of Perspex changed my work dramatically. I had already engraved and printed from a plastic set square in the *Wise and Foolish Virgins*, but now I took much more interest in this transparent medium.

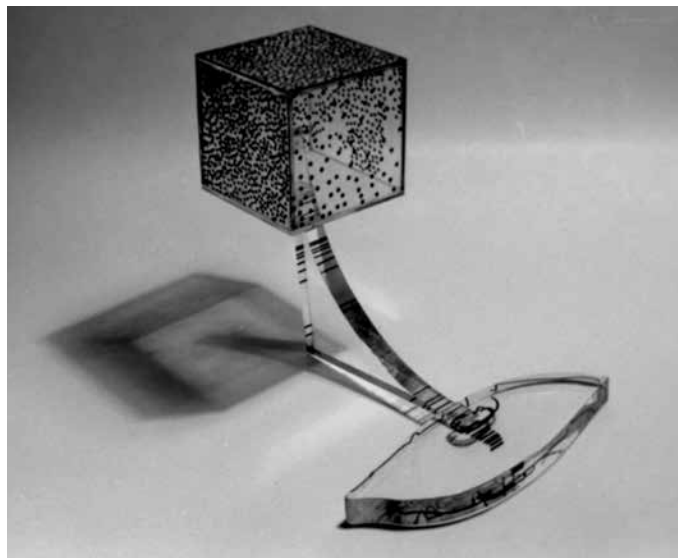
After my return from the US in 1966, I started to use acrylic material to engrave on. Sometimes I worked on simple, prefabricated geometric 3D shapes, like cubes and cones. Once I had engraved onto them, I inked them up like my plates in black ink. I then wiped the surface clean so the ink was trapped in the engraved lines. This was intended to be a sculpture or part of a sculpture, not a print.

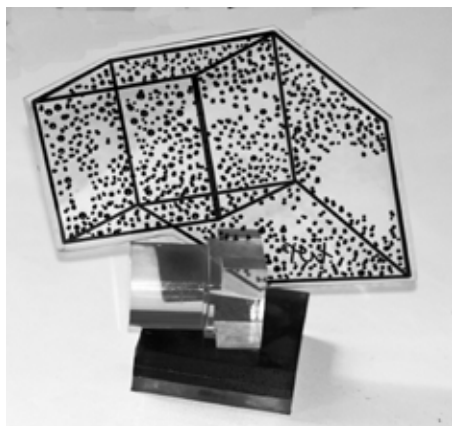
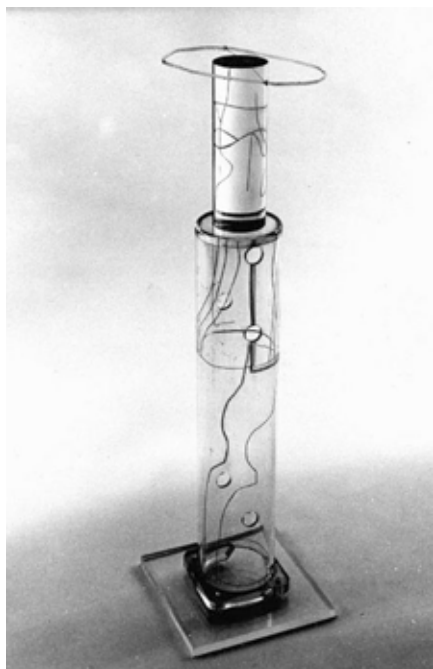
I never make 2D sketches for 3D work; I just use the materials at hand to create the work. However, I often use the theme of a finished piece for a related print, but using an entirely different process. Working from a 3D model when working on paper simply does not work.

When lit with a strong source, whether from the outside or from within the sculpture itself, curious but very precise shadows emerge suggesting extra dimensions. Kinetic elements come into view; Viewers walking around my sculptures see lines swelling and veining by optical illusion.

When working on these sculptures, experimentation might

Agathe Sorel, *Inner Lights*, sculpture 1972





Agathe Sorel, *Echo Chamber*, space engraving drilling and lathe formatting on perspex, 1974

Agathe Sorel, *Hephaistos*, Acrylic sculpture, 1968

take months or even a year. It is very difficult, because it has to work from different angles and different perspectives as you walk around these transparent objects. I do not mind investing the time, because I have to be 100% certain that they work and this is why I ask a lot of money for them. I hope that, 30 or 40 years on, these works are still relevant.

I initially used the plastic off-cuts, mostly tubular, that I had acquired from America. The turning point came with the discovery of a plastics scrap yard in London which has remained a zealously guarded source for the readymade. I would stand under a crane about to break something up and shout stop when I saw something interesting. I work in a different way to the Constructivists such as Gabo who cut and moulded acrylic; I instead adopted a more Surrealist approach, incorporating the idea of the found object. Michael Rothenstein had already absorbed existing wooden textures, and later photography, into his expansive mixed media prints and boxes. I now began to appropriate existing shapes, such as the forgotten remnants of coiled lumps of extruded plastic I found at the dump as the basis of my work.

I referred to these works as Space Engravings, borrowing the



Agathe Sorel, *Macho the Cock (detail)*, perspex and welded steel of cockerel on motorbike with real mirrors and movable steering wheel, 1985

term from Michael Rothenstein, who had, in one of his articles mentioned engravings in space and I rather liked this term. I had good reason to call them space engravings. Sculpture at the time was dominated by mostly male very macho stone carvers, welders or bronze casters, and if I called my work sculpture all hell would have let loose, which in fact happened anyway. I had several major solo exhibitions in the UK, USA, Canada, Sweden, France and Germany, all which achieved critical acclaim.

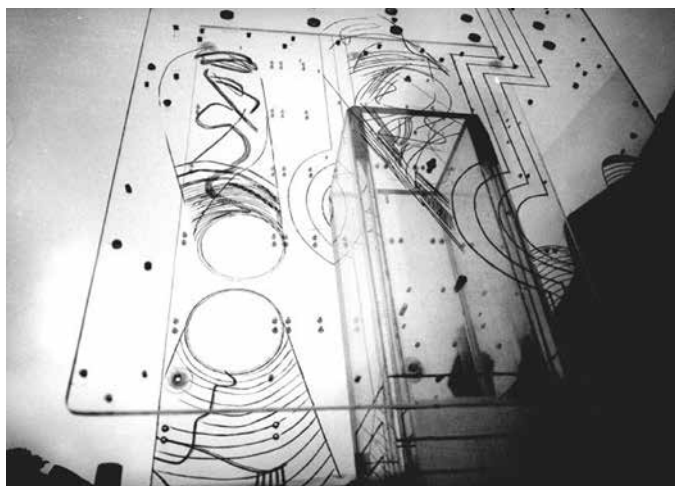
I continue to work in this way. Unlike contemporaries who were drawn to the mechanics of the kinetic, I preferred not to make use of electrical devices. Rather I concentrated on employing the simplest of spot lights to highlight the projections of my chosen materials. In one of my best-known works, *Macho the Cock*, engraved and welded lines work in tandem with the outward projections of shadow, a heightened display of colour, and the actual time spent by the viewer following and moving around these sculptural lines. The movement comes from solid objects which have a line or lines or scored or engraved into their surface. When you start walking around, the lines strengthened by the optical properties of the material, also start moving. The inclusion of real (side) mirrors attached to flat projected shapes like *Macho the Cock* only adds to the possibilities for imaginative interaction with this sculpture.

Nicolas Sapieha

I would like to mention here a former student of mine at Camberwell School of Arts. Nicolas Sapieha was a mature American student, an accomplished photographer, who took extremely interesting pictures for the press at the time, for which he was recognised and well paid. He somehow considered the conditions and the scramble for prime vantage points somewhat undignified and wanted to change tracks. He was also a traditionalist in his technique and this is why he ended up in the printmaking department.

One day I asked him over to my studio to look at my sculpture, which was hellishly difficult to photograph. There was one disastrous occasion a Royal College photographer was recommended to me. He arrived with the equipment of a fashion photographer, a silver foil umbrella and a flashlight that produced hot spots all over the place. The result was so awful I refused to pay him and just gave back his prints. Nicolas, however, had some unusual ideas, which quite honestly scared me, but which worked marvellously well as the pictures were so evocative and atmospheric, that I used them for many years.

He took these rather fragile structures to the roof, into the



Agathe Sorel, *Line in Space*, sculpture photographed by Nicolas Sapieha, 1974



middle of traffic, to abandoned warehouses and industrial estates full of fumes and belching smoke and just kept shooting. When I came to fetch the prints I was just blown away. He gave the negatives to professional printers he trusted as he did not have a darkroom in London.

He soon went back to the USA with a rather peculiar girlfriend, a woman who was rather fashionable at the time with dyed blonde hair,

Left: Agathe Sorel, *Silo detail*, sculpture photographed by Nicolas Sapieha, 1974

Right: Agathe Sorel, *Duo*, sculpture photographed by Nicolas Sapieha, 1974

huge breasts and high heels and seemingly not an idea in her head.

After teaching for many years in Art colleges in the Mid West, where he was valued for his meticulous approach, but wasn't able to use his imaginative powers, he started to travel extensively in Europe, the Middle East and Africa and he undertook assignments. He died in late 1995 of cancer at the age of just 58

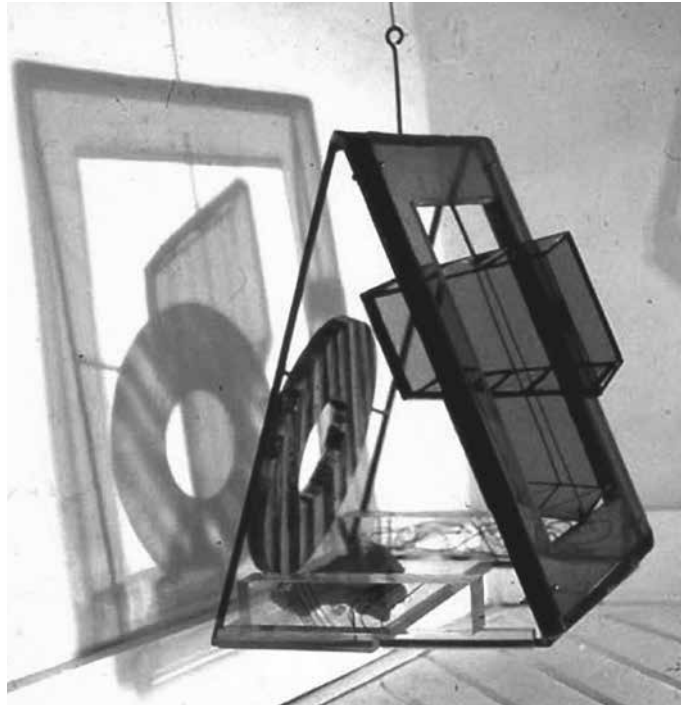
His work is belatedly enjoying a revival and appreciation which is long overdue.

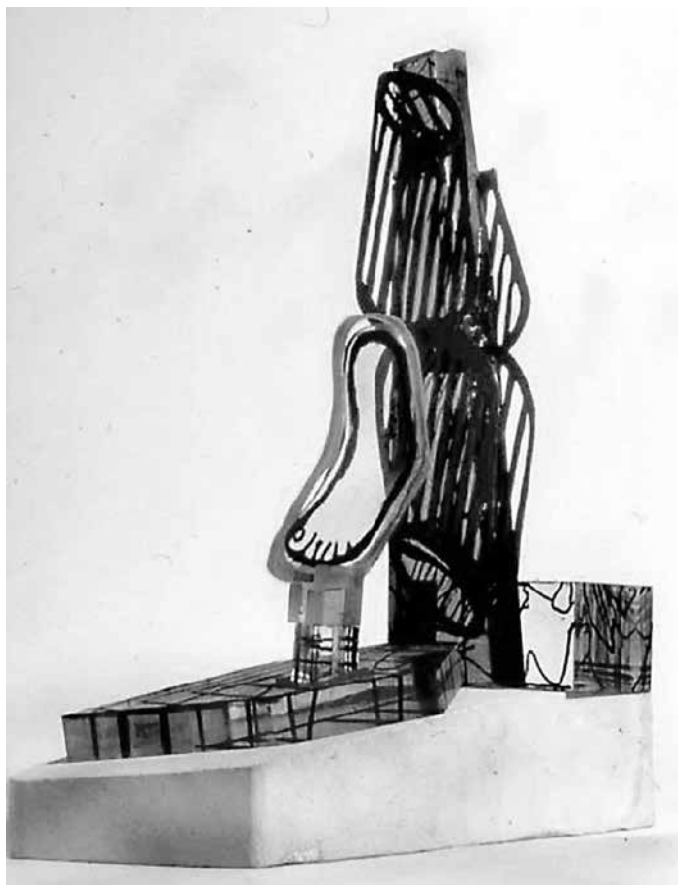
My work in sculpture

A Perspex wall hanging entitled TAO and made in 1965 was one of my first sculptures. It has three main elements. The cyan coloured Perspex was machine and hand engraved, and there is in addition an orange coil and a red cube. With directional lighting, there are pronounced shadows which form part of the composition.

Other notable sculptures included *Welcome Arch* of 1971 sculpture for which I used a piece of pink Perspex onto which I sprayed a yellow half circle. I added various attachments including a purple inkwell with a Welcome insignia. I also added a small colour

Agathe Sorel, TAO,
perspex sculpture
100 x 60 x 52cm, 1965





Agathe Sorel, *Step into the Future, (but be Aware of the Past)*, maquette of steel and perspex sculpture, 1975

print behind a piece of solid Perspex section, hand engraving and photographic transfers of the architectural creations of Frei Otto a German architect who pioneered the use of mathematical, computer based procedures to determine shapes.

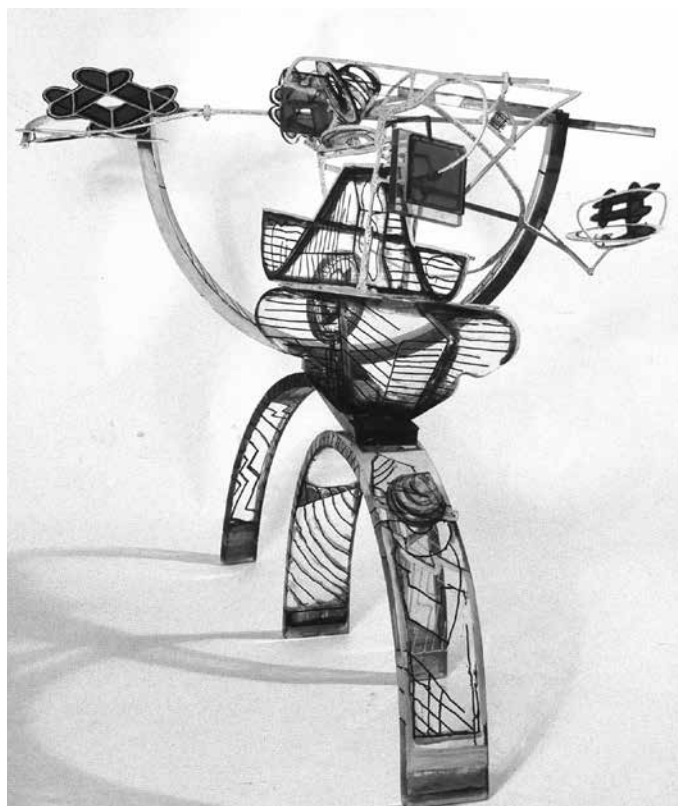
Inner Lights, 1972 (page 114) is made out of a Perspex transparent cube into which I hand drilled holes, mounted on a segmented triangle which is then attached to an oval base, machine. The shadow produced by directional light from this sculpture completes the composition. I then used this piece as the inspiration for a further piece called *Echo Chamber* made in 1974.

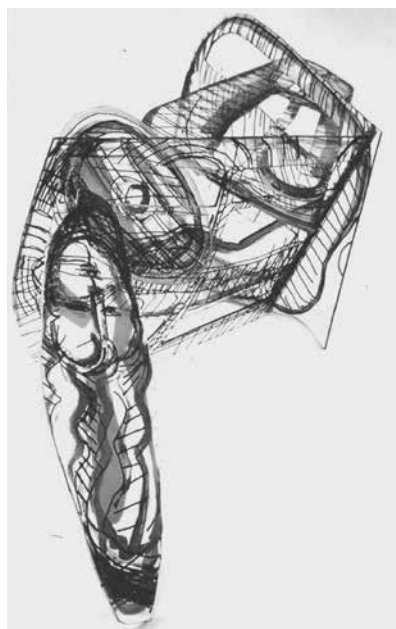
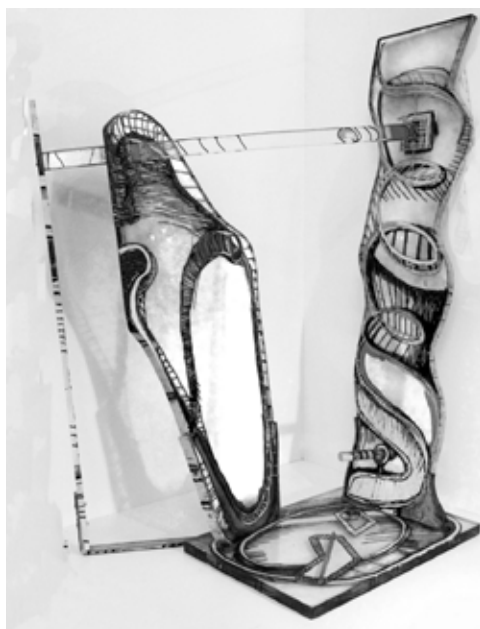
In 1975, I entered a competition organised by Westminster City Council to create a new sculpture for the Strand. The title of the work was *Step into the Future, but be Aware of the Past*. It was

shortlisted for the prize but we were never invited to the private view, as the Council reckoned that the sponsors would not want to meet the artists themselves. I believe the actual expression overheard by one of the artists was that the sponsors would not want to meet the riff raff, which was rather typical of the snobbish attitude of local authorities at the time.

I later made a large print and a book depicting the different stages of the work. I planned to make the sculpture in steel and laminated Perspex. The maquette showed a towering obelisk rising behind a giant engraved Perspex foot which in its final form would have incorporated fluorescent lighting and additional lighting within the fluorescent base. With its use of brightly coloured Perspex, I intended the sculpture to match the metropolitan magic of its Central London location and establish an analogy with the city's own nocturnal transformations.

Agathe Sorel, *Macho the Cock*, perspex sculpture, 1985





"The rules of the game have to be reinvented every time"
Duncan Scott used this quote from the description of my working methods.

The very titles suggest other confrontations, running the gamut from Mediterranean myths to motorbike machismo or Lautremont's chance encounters on a dissecting table, while works like *Echo Chamber TAO* conduct us elegantly into 3-space, 4-space and hypergraphics.

Agathe Sorel combines technical mastery and a zest for experimental making through process with a profound awareness of the twentieth century art within the European cultural tradition. She is insisting on achieving a synthesis between two of the most potent tendencies in twentieth century European art, abstraction and surrealism, and she can affirm that her workshop is a domain of discovery which needs to erect no frontier guards to deny cultural history, poetry, myth or metaphor.

When I made bigger sculptures such as *Macho the Cock* in 1985 or *Grotto for Torus*, 1991, I could no longer work on them on a table. I worked with a Camberwell graduate called Mark Stevens

Left: Agathe Sorel,
***Ego the Goat*, 130 x**
107 x 106 cm perspex
sculpture, 1985

Right: Agathe Sorel,
***Women in Waves*, 950**
x 60 x 560 cm perspex
sculpture, 1985

on incorporating steel armatures into the work to ensure greater stability. I would crawl around the thick, solid piece, engraving lines onto the Perspex. I first marked these out in felt pen and then engraved both sides of the Perspex so that the line became an integral part of the whole structure. I was not aiming at a precious line but a vigorous gestural mark that could be read from a distance. I used a motorised router to create some lines and often combined these with hand worked drypoint and mezzotint. I used a pantograph router to create strong geometric contours. I wanted to expose the colour against the neutral surrounds so hand painting with acrylic or glass paint or stencilling with car spray paint also became part of the

For *Ego the Goat*, 1987 I was inspired by a farmyard scene of a goat climbing over a hill. I used two slanted green slabs of Perspex with rod attachments, added a machine engraved goat horn and part of a giant cork-screw wine press which I placed on a square engraved base. Directional projected shadows complete the composition.

My sculpture *Women in Waves*, 1989 was based on a painting of a man carrying a woman into the sea, but soon I just concentrated on the woman. I visualised her form using open slabs of Perspex bolted together at radical angles. At one end a female head with outspanned hair extends aggressively into space, while opposite there is the enlarged contour of the breast. Multidirectional lines and sections of colour only add to the agitation as the viewer is encouraged to move around the sculpture and see more without any fixed point of contact.

The associated print of the same title was achieved by photocopying the flat parts of the sculpture, and by comparison is restrained in its physical display that is happily buffeted by the surface of sea colour. The focus of attention has shifted to a disjointed arrangement of perspectival lines evoking the idea of internalized dimensions in a figurative form.

The description of the work is drawn from Tessa Sidey's catalogue entries. She was a curator at Birmingham Museum of Art and the curator of my retrospective at Cartwright Hall, Bradford. She visited my studio 13 times in order to analyse and describe this novel and unfamiliar body of work.

Article in Printmaking today www.agathesorel.co.uk

Exhibition in Gravelines 1986

Gravelines is a rather gracious seaside town in Normandy which was popular for summer holidays in Victorian times. Sickert painted the famous lighthouse. The castle and surrounding areas were heavily fortified and used as ammunition dumps in the Napoleonic era.

In 1982 Le Musée de Dessin et de l'Étampe Originale was created, becoming the only museum in Europe dedicated to artists' original prints. It demonstrates the various printing techniques and has presses in the various outbuildings.

The location seemed a bit odd for a major museum as it was half way between Calais and Dunkirk on a minor road, almost impossible to reach by public transport.

I went to visit a couple of times shortly after it opened and was impressed by the ambition and research of its director and staff. They were interested to show my own personal print collection together with my sculpture and an exhibition was organised in 1986

As I walked around the town, I heard that there was a nuclear energy plant hardly a kilometre north of the main square, pumping highly toxic nuclear waste into the sea. I was warned not to be tempted to put even a toe into the water as it was highly dangerous.

The nuclear plant was very conscious of the damage caused to the town and its livelihood and was persuaded by the curator Dominique Tonneau to promote the exhibitions of the museum. They paid for the hotel expenses of all the invitees to the private views, and paid for a grand reception and dinner in a smart hotel in town. And so, it happened, that all the critics from Paris, Brussels, London, in fact from all over Europe arrived with their partners to enjoy a lavish banquet, people who would normally ignore a provincial venue and exhibitions devoted to prints.

Leading articles and editorials appeared the following week praising the quality of the exhibitions. Unfortunately, this did not last long. The Association of Northern Museums started to complain that Gravelines was unjustly singled out for financial support and the money should be shared out equally. As far as I know, although the museum still organises exhibitions, it receives little press coverage.

Exhibition at the Paul Kövesdy Gallery

The Space Engravings were exhibited at the Paul Kövesdy Gallery in New York City in 1989 as one stop on a long tour. On this visit, I did not have to stay at a hotel as I stayed with my cousin Ruth Jaffe and her husband Bob. They put me up in their marvellous apartment overlooking Central Park, a few minutes' walk away from the Metropolitan Museum.

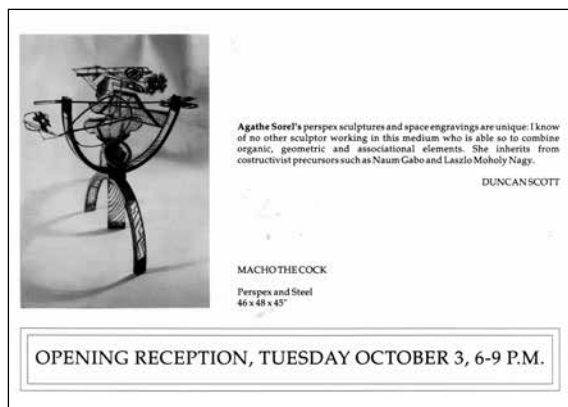
Ruth was a psychoanalyst and her husband a GP. She was brought up in Argentina, to where her family had fled the Nazis before the war. She was also an amateur painter. When I had my show at the Paul Kövesdy Gallery nearby, they very generously offered not only their guest room, but their dining room table as well where I assembled and framed my work.

There were several unexpected complications with this gallery, which were almost comic in their awkwardness. The owner, Mr. Kövesdy, was before 1956 the only acceptable tenor in the Hungarian opera house; strangely, there were world class baritones and bass baritones, but this tiny, slightly effeminate man was the only tenor, standing up in his high heels to huge Wagnerian ladies with sizable bosoms. He behaved as a prima donna on or off the stage. He moved to the USA in 1956, where he was no longer able to compete as a singer, so he decided to go into business as an art dealer. His Gallery had a first-class location and he had some following amongst lovers of modernist and constructivist art.

I brought my own spotlights with me for the sculpture and plugged them into a US adaptor I had bought in the UK. This blew a fuse in the whole gallery, plunging all 35 floors into darkness. We had to call an electrician at once and I had to find a specialist electrical shop on a bank holiday to get the right fitting, which took me to another end of town.

My bad luck continued when I attempted to unpack the large wooden case which was padded out with white polystyrene pellets to prevent damage. In New York, the buildings are so highly charged with static electricity that polystyrene pellets affixed themselves to my nylon stockings. I was desperately trying to get rid of this white swarm following me about,

Invitation card to
Paul Kövesdy Gallery
exhibition, 1989



when another misadventure took me out of the building.

I found, that the welding had come undone on my main exhibit, the acrylic and steel sculpture called *Macho the Cock*, which included the constructivist symbol as part of the composition. I simply could not show it the way it had arrived. Paul Kövesdy rang up an art college, which was luckily in walking distance and a very kind technician welded the joint in 5 minutes; and did not even want to accept payment, seeing it as a favour for a fellow artist in trouble. I jubilantly wrapped the sculpture up and started to march back to the gallery, with enough time to spare before the private view to assemble the sculpture. I was already dressed in my new outfit for the occasion. At this very minute, the rain started to pour down and I got totally drenched. Paul thought that I was simply not presentable and should not attend my own exhibition but I ignored him. To cover up my dripping wet hair, I took some pink tights I had in my bag and wrapped them around my head to make a turban. Luckily, despite my interesting appearance, the critics gave my work good reviews and a couple of sales helped to finance my trip.

André Kertész

I believe Kertész was one of the greatest photographers of all time. Apparently, he was self-taught as his family had wanted him to be a stockbroker like his older brother Imre to whom he was devoted. He went to Paris in 1925, where he was influenced by the Cubists and other avant-garde movements. His work was appreciated for his unusual compositional angles and was published in important magazines such as *Art et Industrie* and *Vu*.

He and his wife Elizabeth travelled to the USA in 1936 as he was keen to look around and to take advantage of new opportunities, but the outbreak of the war forced them to stay. There, his work did not find the same degree of appreciation as he tended to avoid commercial work or advertising. His work was nevertheless shown in museums and at the Art Institute of Chicago and his *Days of Paris* series, made up of photographs taken just before he left Paris, was published in 1945.

We met him in 1983 when he was awarded an honorary doctorate by the Royal College of Art and they asked him to do a series of photos on London. He was pleased to comply.

He came to our house in Wilton Row a couple of times for a Hungarian meal and to complain. He never wanted to part with his easel and camera, would not even let the technician help him to carry them. He was eventually persuaded to let the photographic department of the Royal College develop his pictures as they wanted to have the prints as soon as possible, but he agreed only very reluctantly. Unfortunately, they ruined the negatives with all their photographic experts on hand and the series became a total write off. He was naturally very upset.

My husband met Kertész a second time in New York. He and his wife rented an apartment overlooking Washington Square from where he took amazing pictures with a telephoto lens. He initially developed and printed the photos at home himself, but after 1935 he left this job to trusted printers and his assistant for the last 7/8 years Robert Gurbo, who is now the curator of the Andre Kertesz Foundation.

He was showing his pictures to Gabor, when they realised that they came from the same village in Hungary, Becse. They remembered the landmarks and places they played in, even though they had grown up there several decades apart. He showed Gabor the picture of the goose girl *Fille Gardent les Oies* which I mentioned in my Holocaust diaries and which he then gave to us. It is one of our most treasured possessions. His wife Elisabeth managed to support him throughout by running a successful



André Kertész, *Self portrait*, silver gelatine print, 1927



André Kertész, *Underwater Swimmer*, silver gelatine print, 1917



André Kertész, *Distortion*,
silver gelatine print, 1933



André Kertész, my Paris relatives Ibi and Micu Salgo, who were good friends. This was made in the postcard format between 1928/ 32

cosmetics business. She died from lung cancer having been a heavy smoker all her life. In spite of excellent care, this was and still is a death sentence. For a while André completely lost his bearings

Times changed; his work became highly appreciated and valued. he was given a number of great honours. In 1983, as well as being honoured by the Royal College of Art, he was also nominated Chevalier de la Légion d'Honneur in Paris and was given use of an apartment for future visits to the city. In 1984 his work was shown at the Metropolitan Museum who purchased 100 prints, the largest acquisition by a living artist.

<https://youtu.be/IFPYgKhckH4> several films on Kertes

This recognition came far too late unfortunately as he was already in his 90s and he died in 1985, still an embittered man.

I recently asked a friend if he had any representation in Hungary at the moment and she surprised me with at least 5/6 major exhibitions, some of which showed previously unpublished material.

He was always very generous in giving photographs and advice to people and organizations, wherever he saw a deserving cause. We first came across this during my exhibition at the Camden Art Centre in 1974, when he gave many of his prints to art historian Colin Ford, who persuaded Bradford City council to establish the magnificent and beautifully situated Museum of Photography, with an admirable program of exhibitions and lectures. Unfortunately this museum was shortly closed down through lack of funding and a replacement with the rather non-descript Museum of Communication and the material was subsequently transferred to the Victoria and Albert Museum. He went back several times to Hungary and gave 120 prints and other material to his home village Szigetbecse, where his main museum now celebrates his 125th anniversary. There are photographs of him with other famous Hungarian artists and photographers and the furniture from the Washinton Square flat. He would have been somewhat puzzled of the great honour and worldwide recognition that befell him of having a previously undiscovered planet in the solar system named after him.<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zCr1r4boxdU>

<https://youtu.be/IFPYgKhckH4> KERTESZ FILM ON YOU TUBE

My work in Art Education

“Education in art and design must be a training in innovation. It must concentrate on versatility rather than on learning of established skills, rather than their own sake.”

Laszlo Moholy-Nagy

Education in the 1950s and 1960s was regarded as a social stabilizer, a solution to class division and strife, the bedrock of democracy. Therefore, it was the duty of the state to spread it as wide as possible to benefit everyone who wished to take it up. (Unsurprisingly, there was not a great rush to make use of this opportunity; many working-class families preferred to serve an apprenticeship where they were paid rather than opting for long period of study without pay.) The idea of free education was shared by most western democracies at the time and hardly any fees were paid by the students. There were also scholarships available for the

needy or the exceptionally gifted.

I am very conscious of being the beneficiary of such a system without accumulating huge debts as students tend to do these days.

Cynics say that the government was keen to reduce the arts community to a docile herd by giving them a reasonable income through mostly part-time teaching and good facilities. Tutors were also expected to look after and instruct the students in technical and intellectual skills, preventing strikes, demonstrations and pointless manifestations of rebellion, which in 1968 were beginning to spread from Europe.

From 1958-1968 the conditions were ideal, the facilities were excellent, enough time to instruct the students, free materials and technical assistance were available. All the tutors were practising artists and the results were excellent; most of our students gained places at postgraduate colleges or won scholarships abroad. Many became well known artists.

In 1960 the DIPAD (Diploma in Art and Design) qualification was recognised, pioneered by William Coldstream

Agathe Sorel, *Charm against Evil*, deepbite and drilling colour viscosity print, 1963





Agathe Sorel,
*Electronics for
Beginners*, deepbite
and drilling colour
viscosity print, 1962

and accepted by the National Advisory Council on Education. It encouraged the tuition of theory as well as art history and experimentation between different media was expected. It also allowed students who did not have the necessary academic qualifications to progress as long as they gained these later on during their course. One of these students was Dave Ferry, who later became a distinguished artist and professor of printmaking in Wales and president of the RE. (Royal society of Painter Printmakers)

Polytechnics were created in 1968 but in 1992 everything changed in John Major's *Further and Higher Education Act* when it was decided to create colleges with similar structures to universities. Theoretical subjects became more important and everything had to be reorganised in the name of modernity. In 1993 Camberwell became part of the London Institute and in 2004 it was granted

university status.

Deans and Senior Lecturers were installed, not necessarily practising artists, who engaged in power politics, which would put the United Nations or the Houses of Parliament into shade with their machinations. This was typical of universities as well. I still remember how shocked I was when I read C.P. Snow's accounts of university life. Malcolm Bradbury dealt with the same phenomenon with irony and humour.

As space and amenities became scarce, students were allowed to work from home and to present only written work or conceptual ideas for their final exams. The painting school at Camberwell was closed down and the staff dispersed, while printmaking at degree level was restricted to just 3 months of study, taught mostly by technicians.

The MA in printmaking was kept on a part-time basis where mostly mature international students brought in high fees and received reasonable technical support. Unfortunately, both MA and BA students have missed out on basic skills of drawing and design and the opportunity of handling different materials. These were previously well covered in the year long foundation courses. . At present the fees for a full time taught course are nearly £10,000 per annum plus materials and living expenses

The same scenario appears in most art colleges attached to universities. At present the argument is that artists should not have preferential treatment in the community in harsh times and that they should be encouraged right from the beginning to adopt a sustainable lifestyle. Under the circumstances, it is difficult to see how they could keep up the playful and uncompromising inventiveness, which characterised the best artistic achievements of the past. I am hopeful, that dedicated artists will always find a way to survive even in the most difficult circumstances. Maybe one will have to step outside the traditional educational structures to provide suitable training for them.

There are parallel universes; students are now working in small artist-centred workshops or setting up enterprises on their own, encouraging mindboggling developments, where even experts hesitate to enter without familiarising themselves with the latest theories and products. I find this a most exciting development, which makes a fool of the establishment with its expensive and pretentious university places.

I researched a few artist-led workshops and they include Atelier Contrepoint, Paris, The London Print Workshop South London, Artichoke Print Workshop, Jean Lodge and Angelica Carporaso Print Centre Paris and Print and Press London.

My teaching methods

After writing the previous chapter which is both a historic survey and lament, I was asked to write about my own teaching methods. I was involved part time with BA and MA printmaking courses, throughout my teaching career but also gave lectures on the history of prints with the use of my slide collection and occasionally led life drawing and anatomy classes.

I often used the Hayter method or Gabor Peterdi's handbook on printmaking as an introduction as their methods combined all the basic techniques evolving from etching or soft ground to aquatint and deep-bite singly or in combination. We ended up learning about colour printing mostly through the colour viscosity technique which encouraged a dynamic idiom, where the end result could not be foreseen.

Similar methods were pioneered in other print media, like woodcuts, silkscreen or lithography and quite often the students interacted, especially at art colleges where the studios of the various disciplines were close to each other.

For those who are not familiar with the intaglio process I include a short explanation. In the etching studios, one started by covering a small zinc or copper plate with a mixture of beeswax and asphalt, called soft ground, in which marks were made. The plate was then exposed to acid which bit into those marks.

After proofing the work progressed in several stages and students ended up in a bit of a mess, but this was when the true creative choices kicked in. Drastic alterations had to be introduced which transformed the image into a meaningful symbol. If this was successful, something remarkable happened, if not, one was trained in detached self-criticism so that another attempt could be made until the plate was almost destroyed. This surprisingly offered yet another set of possibilities. Organic growth is not unlike the developments in nature, gradual step-by-step changes leading to new forms of expression or new creatures.

This mindset shows the difference between being guided by a practising artist, rather than a technician who tends to take a single method at a time which produces samplers in a static world.

This attitude of "thinking in the box" is actually encouraged by the galleries and commercial printers as it produces a reliable and predictable product. It also seems to sell as the majority of the public considers art as relaxation rather than a challenge in problem-solving.

The methods I am interested in will change and be in a flux depending on the circumstances of an individual and encourage

both artist and viewer in active participation of thinking and feeling.

The step by step development requires both manual and intellectual skills, the knowledge of drawing and the skill of manipulating materials and subject matter of widely different origins. It also admits chance as an element of creativity as the surrealists and the constructivist demonstrated.

This attitude also exists in the sciences and it is called blue sky thinking and whereas lip service is paid to its importance, only a lucky few individuals are publicly funded to practise it. It is often up to the scientists and artists who subsidise it through their day jobs.

I am glad to say, that there was no house style in my classes and many of my students became well known artists and educators. After so many years I still keep in touch with several of them.

Tom Banchoff

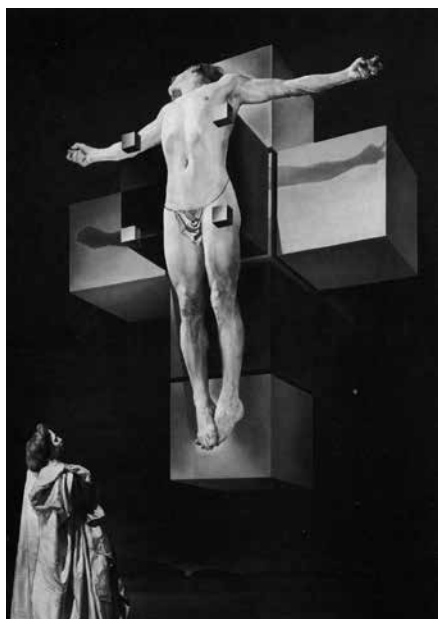
I was invited to Brown University in Rhode Island by an adult student of mine, who was the wife of the Dean Howard Swearer. I was invited to give a lecture about Space and Perspective and how I utilized the various theories which I researched in my sculpture and prints. Students from the well-known Rhode Island School of Design also attended. I got the red-carpet treatment and stayed in the charming colonial guesthouse on my own. I was already aware of the work of mathematician Tom Banchoff at this time and had a couple of his slides about his work in my lectures.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K8wEDRt2omI>

After lunch, I was taken to his office and introduced to him. To my great surprise, I saw a little book on his desk from the scientist I most admire, the Hungarian geometer Imre Pal, whose work I was trying to emulate in my sculpture. It turned out, that Tom was also working with his theories. He also used them in his spectacular films and videos demonstrating multi- dimensional space. Whilst I had no grounding in mathematics or geometry, I achieved a similar multi-dimensional space by engraving on transparent, mostly geometric acrylic objects and subjecting them to spotlights. I lit them both from the outside and occasionally from the inside.

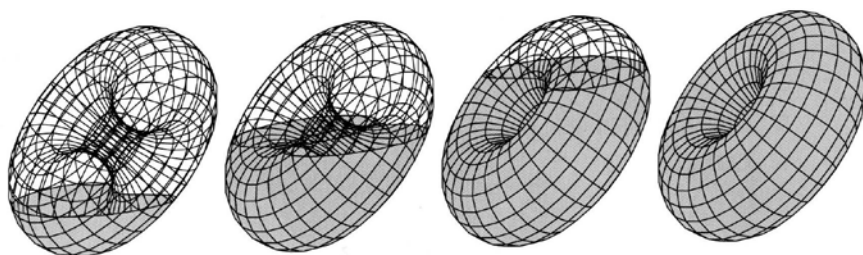
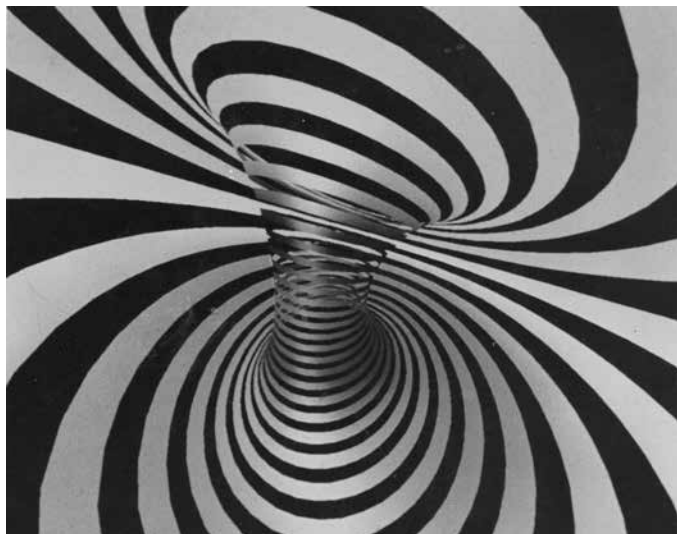


Tom Banchoff with Salvador Dali



Salvador Dali, *Corpus Hypercubus*, oil on canvas, 1954

Tom Banchoff, xxxxxxxx
xxxxxxx



Tom Banchoff, xxxxxxxx
xxxxxxx

Ours was a great meeting of minds and Tom explained that because computing such complex ideas was so time-consuming, he was studying life drawing and drawing in general, so that he could show the students a quick sketch and give them their projects to work out on the computer. He also told me that he was regularly invited to visit the surrealist painter Salvador Dalí who was very interested in his ideas and based some of his paintings on his research including the famous Christ on the Cross painting..

Tom is a lively character who introduced the use of interactive computer software into his classes. Even in 1989, all his students in the lecture theatre had a colour computer terminal in front of them. This was a time when students in UK universities rarely had computers and only lecturers had a little black and white computer screen in their offices, with virtually no usable software for visualising and research.



There was some interesting political manoeuvring going on at the time of my visit, coordinated by the Dean Howard Swearer, who managed to get scientists and artists at the university to participate. Stalin was by then dead and Krushchev and Gorbachev denounced the personal cult which led to the Gulags and the total isolation of the Soviet block from the rest of the world. The cold war paralysed progress in intellectual endeavour. A direct intervention or even an initiative by the White House would have been useless or even counter-productive. A top secret directive arrived from the White House that it was at university level, that collaboration on scientific subjects should be started. This was eventually achieved with remarkable success.

Tom dedicated one of his books to me and with his permission I used some of his images in my work for years to come.

http://www.agathesorel.co.uk/sculptures_installations/21_TAO_1965__br_1000x600x580_mm_406d463126_jpg.html

Teaching at the Canterbury College of Art

I was enjoying teaching at the Canterbury College of Art where for more than 17 years I had remarkable results with difficult students. I worked closely with art historian Duncan Scott who was Deputy head at the time. He was also one of the founders and initiators of the Herbert Reed Gallery. The other person involved was head of painting Stav Parascos. They managed to get the funding mostly from the Herbert Read family to convert the spectacular double height entrance hall into a well-appointed and well-lit art gallery. The university supported the project as it seemed very prestigious and an ambitious and a highly original exhibition program followed with well researched catalogues and posters. The shows were open to the general public as well as university staff and students. Lectures were also held on relevant subjects..

One of the lectures advertised was by Walter Strahan famous critic and collector of livres d'artiste then in his mid-80's who brought his entire collection of books to the college in his battered white van to show to anyone, who was interested. I rang up the college to arrange to attend with my students, who for some unpredictable reason didn't turn up, but having arranged civilised conditions to get Walter started we exchanged ideas and became friends.

I was informed at the following staff meeting in the middle of the term that they discontinued my part time contract and I was sacked. This was most unusual and unheard of in the colleges where I taught.

In the ungainly scramble of the art colleges aiming for university status art education suffered. Printmaking and art generally got marginalized and taught solely as a unit in a BA or MA courses mainly by technicians'.

David Ferry

I first met David in 1976 as a young student at Camberwell School of arts and crafts.

He was 19 years old and did not have the right qualifications, but in those days the colleges were able to grant admission in exceptional cases provided the students got these qualifications during their studies.

One of these students was David Ferry who later became a distinguished artist, professor of printmaking at the university of Wales and president of the RE (Royal Society of Painter printmakers)

At Winchester, where David was senior lecturer the management wanted to get rid of old fashioned disciplines and in his absence went so far as to hire a firm to break up and get rid of a large lithographic press in order to establish an IT hub for computers.

Eventually David managed to track down the breakage firm, bought the press and had it assembled at his own expense. It is now in a warehouse donated to the students for future use.

He continued his career as a professor of printmaking at the Cardiff University when he had 2 fatal injuries on his bicycle broke almost every bone in his body and was forced to retire from his job. It was an absolute miracle that he survived owing to lengthy specialist treatment and physio therapy which he could only afford by sewing the owners of a farm dog, which was involved in the accident, which was luckily according to the law insured.

Soon after his departure Cardiff University, which did not want to be left behind in the modernisation race, hired a firm of breakers to get rid of their beautiful and historic Columbian press with the golden eagle. A specialist firm would have taken the press apart for transportation, but this firm didn't know how to do this and used a big crane installed in front of the college to heave the press out through a window and dropped it breaking it up. At this point nobody was injured, but the Columbian press was a write off. They then asked a local engineer to assemble it, which was not possible as the cast iron once broken could not be repaired. The press collapsed, badly injuring one of the students. It is now out of action, displayed behind glass at the entrance of the college



David Ferry



David Ferry, *Connected Forms*, white marble resin and paint, 2015

demonstrating the foundations and culture of the printed book in England.

This rather typical incident of bungled initiatives by the authorities would be almost hilarious if it was not a tragic indicator of modern university thinking.

The teaching of art and skills are in peril in my view and in one of my previous chapters I recommended alternatives to universities.

Like the disappearance of the white rhino, the snow tiger or the humped backed whale, traditional skills should be maintained and protected, but traditional skills should never be confused with traditional mind sets.

